

BYGONE YEARS Devika Rani and other actors during the shoot of *Jawani Ki Hawa* (1935); (bottom) Josef Wirsching with his camera in Jaipur

When it comes to literature on Indian cinema, cinematographers have been overlooked in favour of actors, filmmakers and musicians. Which is why *Bombay Talkies: An Unseen History of Indian Cinema* is a rare, treasured volume, for it offers cinephiles a glimpse of filmmaking through the gaze of a cinematographer: German lensman Josef Wirsching, who worked with the iconic Bombay Talkies studio from its inception in 1934 until its dissolution in 1954. For editor Debashree Mukherjee, associate professor, Middle Eastern, South Asian, and African Studies, Columbia University, it made anchoring this project all the more enticing. "A focus on cinematographers is both overdue and can tell us some very surprising things about the history of Indian cinema," she wrote from New York. "Our goal was to publicly present, and critically analyse, Josef Wirsching's contributions to Indian cinema. At the same time, unpack the historical significance of this astonishing archive of photographs that he has left behind."

One has to thank Wirsching's son, Peter, and his grandsons, Josef and Georg, for preserving the photographs and negatives for nearly eight decades as the family moved across India. The Alkazi Foundation later stepped up to restore the collection digitally. The black-and-white photographs include umpteen film stills but it's the behind-the-scenes shots capturing filmmaking in pre-Independence India and candid takes that stand out.

Unsurprisingly, the stunning Devika Rani, co-founder of the studio alongside her husband and lawyer-turned-actor Himanshu Rai, and also the studio's leading lady, dominates the pages, be it her turn in *Jawani Ki Hawa* (1935) or *Achhut Kannya* (1936). Also seen is her co-star, an awkward-looking Ashok Kumar, who started off as a laboratory assistant with the studio. Kumar's thespian career was a result of Rani eloping with Najmul Hussain, the original actor of *Jeevan Naiya* (1936), which led to Hussain's dismissal. Other eminent subjects include German director Franz Osten, classical dancer Madame Azurie, producer Sashadhar Mukherjee and sound engineer Savak Vacha.

At the forefront is Wirsching. Georg's foreword details his grandfather's internment in the prisoner-of-war camps in British India during the

ENTERTAINMENT

A WARM COMEBACK

Veteran actress* Sharmila Tagore *talks about her OTT debut with* Gulmohar *and why the character of Kusum spoke to her

When filmmaker Rahul V. Chittella locked in on a house to shoot his directorial debut *Gulmohar*, all he needed to tell the owner was the name of his leading lady: Sharmila Tagore. Says Chittela, "He was eight years old when he got a photograph with Sharmilaji on the front lawn. He lost it. All he wanted was a new photograph with her. That's how we got the house." *Gulmohar* premieres on Disney+Hotstar on March 3.

For the past decade or so, Tagore has largely avoided the spotlight, opting for a quiet, independent life in New Delhi. When Chittella came to her with the character of Kusum in 2019, she had a change of heart. "She spoke to me. She is my age and close to what I am in real life," says Tagore. "There is so much warmth [in the script]. Under one roof, there are many parallel stories, and every character is rounded."

Gulmohar sees Tagore play a matriarch whose decision to sell the family home and live independently

